

Pick Your Puzzle

Four Campus Mysteries, One Month to Solve Them

Systems Thinking & Design — Group Projects

Below are four real puzzles happening on our own campus right now. On the surface, each looks like a simple issue caused by bad habits, rigid rules, or poor planning. But when you look closer, each is tied to a tangled system of people, routines, hidden delays, and unintended side effects.

Pick **one** puzzle for your team. Over the next four weeks, your job is not to suggest a quick band-aid fix, but to figure out why the problem keeps happening again and again, and where a small change could make a big difference.

1. The Breakfast Paradox
2. The 11 O’Clock Cliff
3. The Research Lab Commons
4. The Induction Week Pile-Up

Problem 1: The Breakfast Paradox

A mystery of hot idlis, cold beds, and missing energy.

It is 7:45 AM. Rohan’s alarm has gone off four times. He worked late last night, so choosing twenty extra minutes of sleep gives him immediate relief, while the benefit of eating breakfast feels far away. He rolls back over.

Kadamba prepares breakfast every morning for the entire hostel batch, serving from 7:30 to 9:30 AM. But with early morning classes starting at 8:30 AM, students are caught in a rush. Barely a third of the hostel shows up on most mornings. By 9:45 AM, the counters close, and large trays of untouched, nutritious food are thrown straight into the bin.

The real trouble hits a couple of hours later. By 11:15 AM, stuck in back-to-back lectures, Rohan’s energy crashes completely. He cannot focus because he missed the most important meal of the day. Starving, he runs to VC to buy a quick plate of Maggi. He ends up paying twice for food (the mess fee he already paid, plus cash at the canteen), eats low-nutrition food that makes him sluggish by evening, stays up late to catch up on work, and repeats the cycle the next morning. Meanwhile, his roommate Adit never skips a meal (“I paid for it, why would I waste it?”) and cannot understand why most students do not do the same.

System Question: How do class schedules, sleep habits, food preparation, and daily energy levels feed into each other to create a continuous loop of wasted food and tired students?

Problem 2: The 11 O’Clock Cliff

A mystery of late-night hunger, security rules, and two colliding systems.

It is 10:52 PM, and the campus main gate looks like a small traffic jam. Half a dozen Swiggy and Zomato delivery riders are trying to get inside before the 11:00 PM cutoff, while Raju, the security guard on duty, is trying to check IDs, maintain safety, and follow strict campus rules.

This nightly rush happens because two different parts of campus life are working against each other:

- **The Academic Routine:** Heavy workloads, lab assignments, and group projects force students to work late into the night. Staying awake and focused until 2:00 or 3:00 AM burns energy, making students genuinely hungry for a proper meal.
- **The Campus Safety Policy:** To keep campus secure and discourage students from staying up late ordering junk, external delivery vehicles are banned after 11:00 PM, and late-night food options on campus are kept minimal.

Priyanka has ordered food four nights this week. Campus only has one small canteen open after midnight, but it only sells fried Maggi and chips, which does not provide real sustenance for students working long hours. Because riders cannot enter after 11:00 PM, students ordering late have to walk all the way to the main gate in the dark to collect their food, only to bring back cold meals. Instead of stopping late-night eating, the rule simply adds extra stress and friction to a routine created by the academic schedule itself.

System Question: Why are student academic habits and campus safety rules pulling in opposite directions, and how could both systems work together without creating daily chaos at the gate?

Problem 3: The Research Lab Commons

A mystery of one claimed desk, an empty milk carton, and shared spaces.

On the third floor, two research labs face each other: the Software Lab, blessed with a shared coffee machine, and the Electronics Lab, blessed with a fridge and a microwave. Nobody wrote down rules for how any of these should be shared.

The biggest friction is desk space. Rekha, two years into her PhD, has occupied the corner desk since day one. With her monitor, notebooks, and plants permanently set up, the desk has basically become her personal property. Meanwhile, Aman, an undergraduate needing a desk for just six weeks for his project, is constantly told “nothing is free right now”—even though several desks sit empty for days because their previous owners have already graduated or are away.

The same pattern happens with the coffee machine and the fridge. Whoever arrives first uses up all the coffee and milk, leaving the cartons empty for the rest of the day. Nobody feels responsible for restocking the supplies or cleaning the appliances, yet every joint meeting turns into an argument about who is misusing the space.

System Question: What unwritten habits and incentives cause shared lab resources to be claimed as private territory, and how can a shared space be managed fairly so that everyone gets what they need?

Problem 4: The Induction Week Pile-Up

A mystery of one very small calendar and about eleven different groups who all needed it first.

This one starts with a spreadsheet. Priya from APEX and Karthik from the Clubs Council have the unofficial, impossible job of building the entire Induction Week calendar and handing out slots to everyone who wants one. It's the fourth version this week.

Mr. Vamsi from the Student Life Office isn't part of that scramble—his official welcome sessions were fixed by the administration back in July, first claim on the auditorium, no negotiation. Everything else has to be built around it. When Karthik gives the dance club a Tuesday slot, the robotics club who'd booked it back in June points out the clash. He moves it to Wednesday, only for Priya to say that's when APEX had planned the batch bonding session.

Somewhere in the chaos, Sameer from the Student Parliament asks for just one thing: thirty minutes, at some point, to tell freshers what Parliament actually does. Parliament isn't organising anything, isn't part of the negotiation, has nothing to trade—so his request keeps sliding down the list, and eventually lands at 9 PM on the very last day, right after everyone's energy is already gone.

System Question: When every group tries to maximize its own time with the freshers without considering the bigger picture, how does the whole schedule end up overloaded, and how could the onboarding experience be coordinated fairly?

How the Month Will Work

Every week follows a clear, step-by-step path:

- **Week 1 — Understand:** Look past the obvious symptoms. Talk to the people involved, observe the problem in person, and map out everyone who is affected.
- **Week 2 — Dig Deeper:** Gather real evidence through interviews and surveys. Use the **Iceberg Model** to uncover hidden patterns, underlying structures, and common mindsets.

- **Week 3 — Connect the Dots:** Build a **Causal Loop Diagram (CLD)**. Map out feedback loops, delays, unintended side effects, and points of resistance.
- **Week 4 — solution and Share:** Find high-leverage points to make a meaningful intervention, think through possible side effects, and present your complete journey from problem to solution.

You will receive detailed instructions for each week's deliverable every Monday. Submissions run on a Monday-to-Monday cycle, due before the next week's instructions are released.